AI Dave — Talking Head Reverse-Engineer SOP

Nov 11, 2026 · @dave

What this is

Take someone else's talking-head reel that's working, keep its structure and pacing, and remake it as an AI Dave reel in your story and voice. All AI Dave content is 100% growth. Never copy it: remake it.

The flow: **source reel → teardown → Dave script → talking clips in Flow (Frames mode) → split-screen edit in Remotion → QC → day folder.** One reel takes about 45 to 60 minutes. The target is 2 a day.

Inputs and where things live

What	Where
Source reel	The day folder in Drive (🎬 VIDEO PIPELINE), or Dave drops it into 01 INBOX — To Remake
Flow project	David Ai Systems
Face reference	Collection "New Ai dave images better lighting" (4 images); look = "Dave in Studio 2" (dark studio, mic in hand, blue neon)
Head-angle sheet	The 360 head-angle sheet in the same project, used as the second reference so his hair doesn't flip sides
Never use	The cream-wall image with the mic at the bottom, and the old "AI Dave ref"
Editor	reel-lab (Remotion), split-screen kit
Output	AI_Dave_<Name>_v1_phone.mp4 into the day folder

Approved images (David Ai Systems, checked Nov 11):

Image	Use
DAVE_SHARED_START.png (front, armchair, mic, lantern)	Main start and end frame for every talking clip
Man holding small microphone (close, front)	Close-up clips
Man holding a microphone (3/4, blue neon)	Alternate close-up angle
Man sitting in armchair (wide, blue shoes)	Wide clips and breathers
Man looking into camera (bokeh, no mic)	Face check only. Different room and greyer hair, so never a frame
Man posing in room (bright room, bookshelf, mic at bottom)	BANNED. This is the cream-wall image. Unheart it
Man presenting AI video / Man sitting in chair (text panels)	Cover and thumbnail style only. Never a frame: the text bakes into the video

If any of these can't be found, stop and say so. Don't substitute another image.

Step 1 — Tear down the source

Goal: know exactly why it works before writing a word.

1. **Transcript with timings.** Make a 16 kHz wav, then run `asr.py` (or TurboScribe). Count the words per second; ours is 3.5.
2. **Map every cut.** Run scene detection, take one still per shot and tile them with timestamps into a contact sheet.
3. **Label each beat:** hook (first 3 seconds), problem, story, turn, proof, payoff, CTA. Note how long each one runs.
4. **Note the visual tricks:** top-half graphics, screen recordings, zoom punches, close-up vs wide swaps, captions or none.
5. **Note the CTA:** the comment keyword, what's given away, the follow gate.
6. **Write a 1-page breakdown:** the beat table plus three "why it works" lines. Save it to the day folder.

Step 2 — Write Dave's script

Keep the source's beat order and timing. Swap in Dave's story.

- **Hook (0–3s):** the viewer's problem or feeling, not Dave's numbers. Contrarian beats safe. Example: "You don't need to be on camera to grow a page."
- **Story:** a real moment from Dave's life, for example the $54K spent on TikTok for 20 sales, or paying $1,700 a month for tools before building his own.
- **Turn + proof:** what changed, shown as a result. Say "my system" or "my AI", never the tool's name.
- **Payoff:** what the viewer gets, said as something that can happen for them.
- **CTA:** comment a keyword for a free skill download (the Notion card), plus share and follow first.

Length: 30 to 60 seconds. Split it into 8-second lines of 24 words or fewer, one line per clip. Hand the script to Dave before building.

Step 3 — Build the talking clips in Flow

1. Open David Ai Systems and create a collection: AI DAVE <REEL NAME>.
2. Settings: Video, **Frames**, Omni Flash, 9:16, 8s, x1, Agent off.
3. Use the **same** studio image as the start and the end frame. Two different photos make his hair switch sides.
4. Prompt = the clip ID plus the exact line, then one emotion cue:
    - `AI DAVE <NAME> 01. says: "<line>" Natural head movement, real facial expression, leans in on the key word. ( no music ) ( no on-screen text )`
5. Alternate wide and close-up clips (studio wide, then a close-up) so the cut has somewhere to go.
6. Submit one clip about every 90 seconds. Faster trips "unusual activity".
7. Don't heart items in this project; crossed references came from hearted items. Download the clips straight to the day folder.

Step 4 — Edit in Remotion (split screen)

1. Run a transcript on each clip. Cut every pause over 0.35s and any repeated words, then build `timeline.json`.

2. **Layout:** graphics on top, with Dave in a rounded face card at the bottom. Alternate a 1.0 and 1.05 punch on each jump cut, plus a slow 4% push.
3. **Top half:** one visual per line, changing every 1 to 1.5 seconds, landing on the spoken word. Use real screen recordings first, then Remotion graphics: counters, browser windows with a cursor and zoom, checklists, stamps.
4. **Captions:** bold tight white sans with white serif-italic key words, and no dark band behind them.
5. **Audio:** high-pass at 80 Hz, a slight presence boost, loudness to −14 LUFS.
6. **Render:** run it detached, then make a crf 23 phone copy.

Detail lives in the remotion-split-screen-reel skill.

Step 5 — QC and handoff

- [ ] It's Dave's face in every clip, with his hair on the same side
- [ ] The final cut's transcript reads as the script, with no cut-off or repeated words
- [ ] No dead air over 0.35s
- [ ] Graphics and captions sit inside the safe zone (y 220 to 1470) and are clear of the Instagram buttons
- [ ] No tool names or prices on screen or in the audio
- [ ] The CTA keyword matches the Notion skill card

Then into the day folder: the phone copy, the script, the caption, the DM text with the skill-download link, and the Notion entry. Never post it yourself.

Rules and lessons

1. Remake the reel, don't copy it: keep the structure and pacing, and change the story, words and visuals.
2. Never name or show the tool. Say "my system" or "my AI". No tool prices or credit counts in the reels.
3. Open on the viewer's problem, never on Dave's numbers.
4. Frames mode with one identical start and end image. Ingredients mode drifts his face.
5. More emotion: head movement, facial expression, leaning in. A flat delivery reads as fake.

6. Never show other creators on AI Dave character content. Creator spotlights are allowed only in course reels, muted, under 8 seconds, with the URL visible.
7. Write every new mistake into this doc the same day.